

Theotokos, Hosios Lukas

Location Phocide, Greece

The later 10th-century church of the Theotokos is one of two churches at the Greek Orthodox monastery of Hosios Lukas. Its significance lies in the fact that it was the first church to be built in what would become the dominant plan of Byzantine ecclesiastical architecture: the cross-in-square, or crossed dome. Within an overall rectangular floor plan, a square is formed in the center of the building by four piers, and from it project four identical arms at right angles. As is typical, a dome rises from the central space. Smaller domes over the arms were a characteristic later development. The church's design would prove immensely influential. Its symmetry not only satisfied the Byzantine near veneration of geometry but also lent itself to the complex hierarchical decorative schemes, almost always in mosaic, that reinforced Byzantine liturgical practices.

Cathedral of Santa Sophia

Location Novgorod, Russia

The influence of the Byzantine cross-in-square plan (see Theotokos, Hosios Lukas, above) is reflected in Novgorod's mid-11th-century Orthodox Cathedral of Santa Sophia. Its five onion domes—the central one gilded, the rest silvered—rise to a height of 125 ft (38 m) over the heart of the church. However, its asymmetry, small windows, and vertical emphasis suggest an influence from the massive Romanesque cathedrals simultaneously appearing across parts of Western Europe. It is the oldest existing church in Russia, which was first reached by missionaries in only 933 CE. The church has remained mostly unchanged externally since it was built, and its stern appearance is emphasized by its plain white



walls. However, much of the decoration in the dimly gleaming interior is from the late 19th century.

Ely Cathedral

Location Ely, England

Ely Cathedral is remarkable for its huge bulk, most memorably seen in silhouette, which reveals a long, low building with various towers and spires. It contains prime examples of almost every major period of the Gothic style in England, as well as an 11th-century Norman nave and transepts with sturdy, round-headed arches. The West Tower over the main entrance is a similarly bulky Norman structure. By contrast, the 14th-century Lady Chapel is a riot of exuberant carving. However, the most distinctive feature is the huge eight-sided tower, or octagon, over the crossing, built in 1322–1340. From it climbs a second, wooden octagon.

Maria Laach Abbey

Location Rhineland, Germany

By the end of the 11th century, economic revival, an assertive Catholic Church, and the continuing rediscovery of the engineering feats of the Romans made possible a series of vast, vaulted stone-built cathedrals in Western Europe. In early medieval terms, they were extraordinary technical triumphs. The Romanesque Benedictine abbey-church of Maria Laach, completed after 1093, is a prime example. Its most obvious feature is not just its size and uniformity, but the impact of its bold masses—above all its imposing towers, three at each end, with the square tower at the west end being the most dominant. Boldly projecting apses reinforce the sense of massive masonry. The heavily shadowed interior is as daunting as it is impressive.

▲ THE ROUND STONE CHURCH CAPPED BY A CONICAL WOODEN ROOF AT OSTERLARS

Osterlars Church

Location Bornholm Island, Denmark

Like Norway's "stave" churches (see p.128 and p.332), the stone church at Osterlars, built on the Baltic island of Bornholm in c.1150, belongs to no recognizable tradition of European architecture. Instead, it represents the response of local Scandinavian traditions to Christianity, which by the mid-11th century was spreading across the former Viking world. The building, rough-hewn under its conical wooden roof, is circular. Its near-windowless interior boasts a remarkable column—hollow in its center, pierced by a series of round arches—that spreads outward to support the roof. A band of frescoes, probably dating from the 14th century, encircles it. They include a vivid representation of the Last Judgment, in which hell is represented by a dragon.